



Copal

△ **Translucent** golden copal nugget from New Zealand

Copal is semi-fossilized tree resin from the copal tree, *Protium copal*. It differs from amber, which also results from tree resin, in that it is far younger – copal is less than 100,000 years old, while amber may be millions of years in the making. For this reason, copal is more common and thus cheaper, although it is often used to imitate amber. Copal has historically been burned as incense, especially in offerings to the Mayan gods in Mesoamerica. Europeans later valued it as an ingredient in wood varnish, particularly during the 19th and 20th centuries.

Specification

Chemical name Copal gum | **Formula** $C_{10}H_{16}O$
Colours Light lemon yellow to orange | **Structure** Amorphous | **Hardness** 2–3 | **SG** 1.05–1.10 | **RI** 1.54
Lustre Resinous | **Streak** n/a | **Locations** Malaysia, Philippines, Africa, Colombia, New Zealand



Forest-floor copal | Rough | The flattened, globular shape of this example of copal is the result of its original resin forming a pool on the forest floor.

Liquid-like surface

Clear interior



Gemmy copal | Colour variety | This group of gemmy, light to dark honey-coloured copal pieces shows a variety of different shades and colours.

Copal is still burned as a form of incense in sweat lodge ceremonies in Mexico and Central America

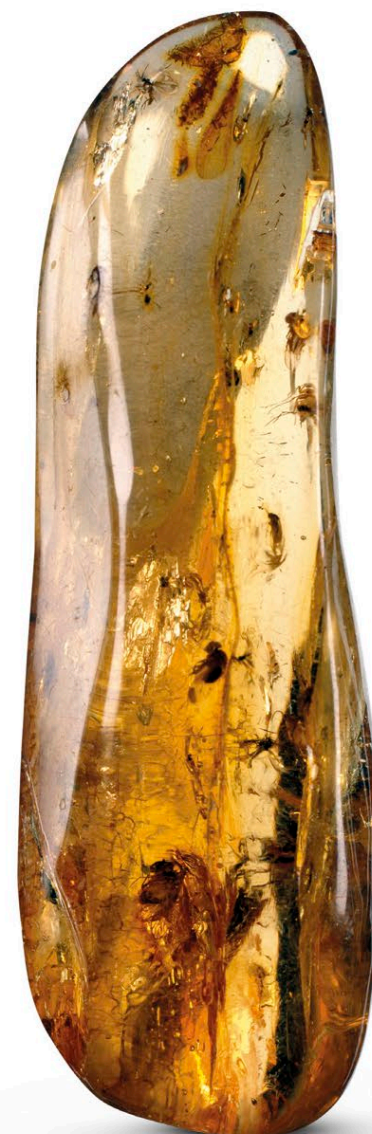


Copal slice | Rough | This thin slice of copal contains a few well-preserved insects, and is notable for its country of origin, Madagascar.

Insect wings



Trapped insects | Cut | This polished copal example is dotted with trapped insects, pollen, and seeds, in a similar manner to pieces of amber.



Dominican copal | Cut | This striking piece of polished copal from the Dominican Republic is also populated with trapped flies, spiders, and midges.